aircraft killing all 329 passengers and crew. India's frustrations grew when the Kanishka judicial inquiry dragged on fruitlessly for years, resulting in the acquittal of many of the key accused. More recently, Sikh extremists have captured several gurdwaras across Canada, with many displaying signs saying, "Indian officials and dogs not allowed." These gurdwaras have allegedly become a major source of funds as well as secret sanctuaries to nurture militants.

TRUDEAU'S POLITICAL COMPULSIONS

Politically, Sikh voters are influential in only 20-25 constituencies, but, given the nature of Canadian politics, can prove decisive in government formation. As happened in the most recent parliamentary election in 2021, when Trudeau's Liberal Party won only 160 seats, falling 10 short of the majority mark of 170 needed in the 338-member house. It was the Left-leaning New Democratic Party, headed by Jagmeet 'Jimmy' Dhaliwal, that extended support to the Liberals with its 25 seats and enabled Trudeau to form a government and return as prime minister. Now serving his third term as prime minister (eight years in all), Trudeau has become increasingly unpopular, largely for domestic reasons, particularly for his government's shoddy handling of the economy. Latest Canadian opinion polls indicate his personal popularity is at its lowest ever and were a general election to be held now, the Liberals will be ousted and the Conservatives win a handsome majority on their own. On the foreign policy front, Trudeau has been on the back foot in Parliament over the charge that China had exercised influence over the outcome of the previous general election and the prime minister had done nothing about it.

Trudeau's relations with India have always been rocky and his equation with Modi marked by a palpable lack of chemistry. What bothered New Delhi is the presence of Trudeau and his ministers at events organised by Khalistan outfits in Canada. His first official visit as prime minister to India in 2018 turned out to be somewhat of a diplomatic debacle. Especially after news broke that Jaspal Atwal, a former member of the banned International Sikh Youth Federation (ISYF) and an ex-convict, was invited to an official dinner Trudeau was hosting in Delhi. The then Punjab chief minister Amarinder Singh had also refused to meet Canada's defence minister Harjit Singh Sajjan, terming him a "Khalistani sympathiser". To make matters worse, Trudeau was apparently miffed that Modi didn't come to the airport to receive him personally as he did for other foreign leaders. Then, during his bilateral meeting with Modi, the Indian PM lectured him sternly for doing precious little to prevent Canada from becoming a haven for Khalistan terrorists. According to the Indian government's assessment, after the 2021 election, Trudeau's political position has weakened considerably and he has strong political compulsions to back the Sikh immigrant community to retain power.

BOTH SIDES NEED TO GET OFF THE HIGHWAY FOR QUIET TALKS INSTEAD OF SPEEDING HEADLONG INTO CONFLICT



For India, this was a deeply bothersome development. While Khalistan extremists had lain quiet during the Covid-19 pandemic, there has been a resurgence of activities in the past two years. Worse, there was a growing nexus between Punjab's ganglords, who indulged in extortion and drug-smuggling, and Khalistan extremists, many of whom used Canada as a base. The Modi government had reached out to the large Sikh diaspora by agreeing to open a pilgrim's corridor between India and Pakistan for the Kartarpur Gurdwara in November 2019. India had also considerably whittled down the blacklist of Sikh extremists and allowed 312 of them, who were earlier banned, to enter India. Prior to the Punjab assembly election, Modi's actions even drew praise from Ripudaman Singh Malik, a former Babbar Khalsa International (BKI) activist, who was one of the main accused in the Kanishka bombing but was acquitted in 2005. He was promptly dubbed as an "Indian central agency stooge" and, in July 2022, shot dead in Surrey.

Among the chief suspects was Nijjar, who had been at loggerheads with Malik for years, especially over the rights to print the Guru Granth Sahib. Nijjar's killing was seen as a gang rivalry between extremists to settle scores. On September 20, two days after Trudeau went public with his allegation against India, Sukhdool Singh alias Sukha Duneke, as-